

Sylvan Zheng

New York University Department of Politics
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EDUCATION

New York University

PhD Candidate, Wilf Department of Politics

Dissertation Committee: Pat Egan, Joshua Tucker, Hye Young You

New York, NY

August 2021 - Present

New York University

MPS, Interactive Telecommunications, Tisch School of the Arts

New York, NY

2019 - 2021

Yale University

BS, Computer Science, cum laude

New Haven, CT

2013-2017

SELECTED WORKING PAPERS AND PUBLICATIONS

Under Review. "Out of Touch: Economic News and Institutional Trust" (academic job market paper)

Under Review. "Ambiguity-Robust Dictionaries with Contextualized Embeddings" (with Jamil Citarevese)

Working Paper. When Coverage Diverges from Politics: Source Selection in Climate News (with Hye Young You)

Working Paper. "Digital Rubbernecking: Consumption vs. Engagement Social Media Feed Optimization" (with Jennifer Allen and Chris Barrie)

Working Paper. The Prosocial Ranking Challenge: Reducing Polarization on Social Media without Sacrificing Engagement (with Jonathan Stray, George Beknazar-Yuzbashev, Kylan Rutherford, Mateusz Stalinski, and others)

2025. "Applications of GPT in Political Science Research: Extracting Information from Unstructured Text" (with Kyuwon Lee, Simone Paci, Jeongmin Park, and Hye Young You), *PS: Political Science & Politics*

2023. "A 2 million-person, campaign-wide field experiment shows how digital advertising affects voter turnout." (with Minali Aggarwal, Jennifer Allen, Alex Coppock, Solomon Messing, Kelly Zhang, Dan Frankowski, et al) *Nature Human Behaviour*

RELEVANT EMPLOYMENT

Local News Lab at Columbia University

Machine Learning Engineer

Design and implementation of network-data powered recommendation system for local newsrooms. Data ingestion, model training, and rec serving infrastructure supports millions of daily page-views.

New York, NY

2021

Acronym

Senior Software Engineer & Data Scientist, Digital Political Ads Measurement

Research, development, and deployment of a statistical model used to predict political messaging effects from social media data throughout the 2020 election season. Development of software used to manage and launch field experiment treatments and surveys on Facebook. Data analysis and presentations of field experiment results.

New York, NY

2020-2021

Facebook (Meta)

Software Engineer, Civic Engagement and Election Integrity

Technical driver of product intervention experimentation processes, data analysis, and heuristic and metric construction to understand and mitigate politically motivated harassment on Facebook. Launched and analyzed four product experiments across feed ranking, automated content moderation, and user feedback surfaces. Designed international politician data infrastructure initiative along with two other engineers and non profit partner organizations. This data powered the Facebook ballot product in a dozen countries.

New York, NY

2017-2019

TEACHING

(UG) **Power and Politics in America (Teaching Assistant)**: 2026
(G) **Quantitative Methods: Causal Inference (Teaching Assistant)**: 2025
(UG) **Social Media and Politics: Senior Seminar (Course Assistant)**: 2024

AWARDS, FELLOWSHIPS, AND GRANTS

NISS Dissertation Grant (Department Nomination): 2025
Institute for Humane Studies Research Award: 2023
Light Fellow, Yale University: 2015

CONFERENCES AND PRESENTATIONS

American Political Science Association: 2026 (presenter, Political Communication, PACSS pre-conference) , 2025
Data Science Frontiers: Society and Politics: Fall 2026 (poster presentation)
Center for Social Media, AI, and Politics Conference: 2025 (presenter), 2026 (presenter)
American Political Science Association: 2025 (presenter)
Midwest Political Science Association: 2024 (presenter)
Northeast Workshop for Empirical Political Science: Spring 2026, Fall 2025, Fall 2024 (discussant)
Money in Politics, Copenhagen: 2024 (presenter)
Rebecca Morton Experiments Conference: 2024, 2023 (poster presentation)
IC2S2: 2022 (presenter)
ITP Tech and Society: 2020 (presenter)